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FOUNDATION HISTORY

One of the oldest American foundations, the Russell Sage Foundation was established in 1907 for “the improvement of social and living conditions in the United States” by a gift of \$10 million from Margaret Olivia Slocum Sage (1828–1918), widow of railroad magnate and financier Russell Sage. Mrs. Sage directed the foundation to pursue its mission through a broad set of activities, including “research, publication, education, the establishment and maintenance of charitable or benevolent activities, agencies and institutions, and the aid of any such activities, agencies, or institutions already in existence.”

[THE RUSSELL SAGE FOUNDATION CENTENNIAL, 1907-2007 >](#)[FORMER AND CURRENT PRESIDENTS, CHIEF OPERATING OFFICERS, AND TRUSTEES >](#)



Margaret Olivia Sage

Also known as Olivia Sage (September 8, 1828 – November 4, 1918), was an American philanthropist known for her contributions to education and progressive causes. In 1869 she became the second wife of industrialist Russell Sage. At his death in 1906, she inherited a fortune estimated at more than \$63,000,000, to be used at her discretion.

Letter of Gift

To the Trustees of Russell Sage Foundation:

I have transferred to Russell Sage Foundation...a fund, the principal of which...shall be held, and the income thereof applied to the improvement of social and living conditions in the United States of America...

The scope of the Foundation is not only national but is broad. It should, however, preferably not undertake to do that which is now being done or is likely to be effectively done by other individuals or by other agencies. It should be its aim to take up the larger and more difficult problems, and to take them up so far as possible in such a manner as to secure co-operation and aid in their solution...

Yours sincerely,
Margaret Olivia Sage
New York, April 19, 1907

A former teacher, Sage strongly supported education, both with program and building grants to Syracuse and other universities. She established the Russell Sage Foundation in 1907 and founded Russell Sage College in 1916, as well as endowing programs for women.

Historical Timeline



April 19, 1907

Margaret Olivia Sage (1828-1918) establishes the Russell Sage Foundation as the nation's first general purpose foundation with an initial gift of \$10 million, part of the fortune she inherited upon the death of her husband, Russell Sage, in 1906. Mrs. Sage directs the new foundation to pursue research and programs

for the improvement of social and living conditions in the United States of America.



Robert W. De Forest played a large role in shaping the Foundation's early undertaking as Mrs. Sage's attorney, her most trusted advisor, and as an influential member of the board of trustees. A leader of the New York Charity Organization Society, de Forest guided the Foundation towards efforts to understand and alleviate the conditions that cause poverty, rather than providing direct assistance to the poor.



May 1907

The Foundation funds the Pittsburgh Survey, the first systematic effort to survey the employment and living conditions among the working class in a large U.S. city. The findings inspire reforms regulating working conditions and the employers' liability system, and help end twelve-hour days and seven-day weeks for steel workers.



1907-1914

The Foundation sponsors early research on programs in housing, public health, working conditions, education, consumer credit, industrial relations, social surveys, and social statistics. These programs lead to legal reforms in building codes, workplace health and safety regulations, workmen's compensation and anti-usury laws.

**1910**

Mary van Kleeck joins RSF's Department of Industrial Studies to study the working conditions of women. Her book *Women in the Bookbinding Trade* leads to legislation banning the employment of women in factories between 10 p.m. and 6 a.m. Over the next 45 years, Van Kleeck builds a remarkable record of industrial relations research at Russell Sage, conducting studies of working conditions, unemployment, collective bargaining and economic planning.



Mary van Kleeck

[VIEW MORE](#)

In the century since Mrs. Sage first dedicated her Foundation to the betterment of social and living conditions, the institution she created has evolved in many ways — beginning as a source of information and support for private social agencies in its earliest years, and gradually becoming a research organization dedicated

to strengthening social science and bringing it more effectively to bear on describing and analyzing the nation's changing social problems. It was Mrs. Sage's foresight in allowing the Foundation to adapt to unanticipated circumstances that has allowed RSF to pursue its founder's intentions in a variety of fresh and creative ways over the long life of the institution. As we look ahead to the next hundred years, it will be a challenge to do as well.

Archives

The Russell Sage Foundation archives reside at the Rockefeller Archive Center. Prospective researchers should contact the Center for further information.

[DOWNLOAD FOUNDATION TIMELINE](#)

More About Our History

THE RUSSELL SAGE FOUNDATION CENTENNIAL, 1907-2007

On Thursday, April 19, 2007, the Russell Sage Foundation celebrated the 100th anniversary of its founding by Mrs. Margaret Olivia Sage in 1907. To mark the occasion, the Foundation held a day-long symposium focused on some of the principal issues that have concerned the Foundation over its long history—and which continue to engage RSF as it moves into its second century.

[MORE ABOUT THE CENTENNIAL >](#)

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